

# A Living Map of Sacred Literature — Project Brief

*The cornerstone document. When in doubt, this file wins. Hand it to any AI assistant at the start of a session so it builds what we actually mean.*

---

## 1. What this is

A **free, open-access, interactive educational resource** — a timeline and a world map — that shows how religious literature developed. It began with the ancient Near East, from the **Kesh Temple Hymn (c. 2600 BCE)**, and now covers **world religious literature across all eras** on the same principles: the Near East and early Christianity, Vedic/Hindu, Chinese, and Buddhist traditions, ancient Egypt, and — going forward — every major tradition up to the present day, not as separate projects but one continuously growing map.

It is built by directing an AI in plain English ("vibe-coding"), not by hand-writing code.

---

## 2. Guiding philosophy — the cornerstone

The project exists to educate, not persuade. It is descriptive, not argumentative. For every text, tradition, or historical claim, it must:

- **Distinguish four things clearly:** historical evidence · scholarly consensus · alternative scholarly views · speculative connections.
- **Show a confidence level** where appropriate: well-established · probable · debated · speculative.
- **Cite reliable academic sources** whenever possible.
- **Never present a disputed theory as settled fact.**

It should invite people to explore the evidence themselves by showing when, where, by whom, and in what cultural context each text was composed, preserved, and transmitted. The values are transparency, historical rigor, and respect for scholarly uncertainty — so that users of any background or belief can investigate and draw their own conclusions. This applies equally to every tradition covered, Near Eastern or Far Eastern.

---

## 3. Scope guardrail — stay macro

Work at the level of major texts, traditions, peoples, and empires. Avoid descending into every denomination, sect, school, or philosophical sub-branch unless a specific one genuinely carries the historical story. Breadth and clarity over exhaustive subdivision. We can always zoom in later; we do not start there.

This applies to every expansion: major traditions and their foundational texts (e.g., the Rigveda and Upanishads, the classics of early Chinese thought, the earliest Buddhist canon, the Pyramid Texts) — not every regional cult, later commentary tradition, or philosophical school.

**Prioritize connected traditions.** Add traditions and texts that have a real, arguable historical connection — of any confidence tier, including debated or speculative — to something already on the map before reaching for traditions with no plausible contact at all (e.g., Norse, Mesoamerican, or precolonial African literatures relative to the Near East/Asian/Egyptian web built so far). Unconnected traditions are still valuable and welcome; just don't skip a connected one to get to them.

---

#### 4. How the app handles uncertainty (rules it must follow)

- Every dated item shows a **date range** plus a **confidence tier** (well-established / probable / debated / speculative).
  - Every significant claim is tagged by **type** (evidence / consensus / alternative view / speculative connection).
  - Influence links between texts are styled by claim type — for example: solid line = documented literary dependency; dashed = probable; dotted = debated or speculative — and each link carries a short note and a source.
  - Sources appear on every entry. Disputed things are shown as disputed.
- 

#### 5. Technology decisions (all free; AI-built)

- **Plain JavaScript + React + Vite.** (TypeScript can come much later, if ever.)
  - **An accurate world map, hand-drawn in style** — real latitude/longitude so every region sits in true relative position, but never a modern political map: no modern borders, no satellite imagery, just rivers, coasts, cities, and regions drawn in the same ancient, schematic style as before. D3 used where helpful for the projection.
  - **A non-linear timeline.** Now that the map covers all eras, a straight line from 2600 BCE to today would squash the ancient world — where most of the current content lives — into an unreadable sliver. The timeline compresses sparse stretches and gives more visual room to eras with real content, rather than scaling strictly by year. It's still honest about dates (every entry keeps its real date range) — just not literally to scale.
  - Later: QGIS for serious historical geography; Inkscape optional.
  - Two homes for the work: (1) A fast design-studio chat for trying ideas, no setup. (2) Claude Code on the Mac — the permanent project, version-controlled with Git/GitHub, published free (GitHub Pages) so it is genuinely open-access.
- 

#### 6. Data model (what one entry looks like)

**Each text:** title · date range · confidence tier · claim type · origin place · city · people / civilization · language · script · religious tradition · literary genre · short summary · historical significance · sources · influences (each: which text, relationship, claim type, short note, source).

**Each people/culture:** name · active date range · short note. **Each place:** name · approximate location (now real latitude/longitude) · short note.

---

## 7. Roadmap (always keep a working version at every step)

- **Phase 1 — done:** map + timeline + ~18 texts + culture bands + influence lines + info panel.
  - **Phase 2 — done:** ~20–30 core texts with real sources and the four-tier tagging.
  - **Phase 3 — done:** gentle animation of peoples and cities over time (empires kept schematic and honest about uncertainty).
  - **Phase 4 — done:** a dedicated influence view, styled by claim type.
  - **Phase 5 — done:** planted in Claude Code on the Mac, published free and open-access on GitHub Pages.
  - **Phase 6 — done:** upgraded the map to accurate world geography (real latitude/longitude, same hand-drawn ancient style); added Vedic/Hindu, Chinese, and Buddhist foundational texts, then ancient Egyptian religious literature — all on the same macro, four-tier-tagged, real-sourced basis as everything else.
  - **Phase 7 — in progress:** pivot to world religious literature across all eras. Build the non-linear timeline; add traditions in order of how strongly they connect to what's already here (Islam next, since it directly engages Jewish and Christian scripture already on the map), before reaching for traditions with no historical contact at all.
- 

## 8. Standing sources

**Near East:** ETCSL (Sumerian literature) · ORACC (cuneiform corpus) · Pleiades (ancient places).

**South & East Asia:** GRETIL (Göttingen Register of Electronic Texts in Indian Languages, Sanskrit/Pali) · CBETA (Chinese Buddhist Electronic Text Association) · Chinese Text Project (ctext.org, pre-modern Chinese texts).

Plus reputable critical editions and scholarly handbooks throughout. Prefer scholarly consensus; flag alternative views; label speculation as speculation.